

Handout

Lecture 1

Psychology Defined

Psychology is **the scientific study of human minds and their functions**. The study involves various aspects in human functioning. These include our **behaviors** (i.e., both the overt and covert ones), our **feelings and emotions**, our **cognition and relevant processes** (e.g., our perception, schema, judgment and decision making, thinking patterns), and our **underlying physiological responses** (e.g., our bodies' automatic reactions in various situations). The **interactions** of these aspects of our minds are also within the scope of the study of psychology.

Key characteristics of psychology: Scientific & ethical considerations

With the complexity and comprehensiveness of psychology, the purposes of studies within psychology can be for **scientific knowledge accumulation** and **daily applications**. With such applications, intuitions are sometimes applied to explain phenomena relevant to psychology. **Popular psychology** (i.e., pop psychology), or speculative information about human minds and their functions that find credibility among mass population, emerges. Whereas some of this information appear sound and practical, its reliability and validity should be viewed with caution.

Scientific or research evidence becomes the ground upon which speculative information about psychological phenomena should be evaluated. The degree to which these explanations are considered valid depends on how well they can be replicated using **systematic research investigations** among various groups of individuals. Rigorous research studies, hence, are conducted in psychology to ascertain that the body of knowledge obtained is theoretically/conceptually sound and very well supported with rigorous research evidence.

In addition to empirical research evidence, practices in psychology, both in knowledge accumulation and applications, are guided by **ethical principles** (American Psychological Association, 2003). Adherence to the five principles is mandatory. In Principle A, Beneficence and Nonmaleficence, psychologists strive to benefit those they serve and take care to do no harm to them. In Principle B, Fidelity and Responsibility, psychologists establish relationships of trust with their service recipients. They are also aware of their professional and scientific responsibilities and uphold their roles and obligations as well as their professional standards. In Principle C, Integrity, psychologists seek to promote accuracy,

honesty, and truthfulness in the science, teaching, and practice of psychology. In Principle D, Justice, they recognize that all service recipients are entitled to fairness and justice. Last but not least is Principle E, Respect for People's Rights and Dignity. Psychologists respect the dignity and worth of all individuals, and the rights of service recipients to obtain privacy, confidentiality, and self-determination.

Domains in Psychology

With various aspects of the minds and their potential interactions, there are various domains of studies in psychology. Some are **theory-based** and focus on accumulating the knowledge in relevant domains. These are, for example, cognitive psychology, which focuses on examining some of the relevant components and processes in our thinking and information processing. Developmental psychology outlines rationales and manners in which individuals change across their lifespan. It also investigates the implications of such changes, which entail various domains (e.g., physical development, cognitive development, personality and social development). In addition to these intrapersonal aspects, understanding the nature and dynamics of interpersonal relationships become the focus of some domains in psychology; namely, social psychology. Relevant examples in this domain include how individuals perceive one another, how ones get influenced by the perception of peer pressure, or why ones become hesitant to offer help when being among other bystanders.

The knowledge accumulated by the theory-based domains of psychology has been applied to enhance individuals' daily functioning and is essential for subsequent utilization in the domains of psychology that are **application-based**. Examples of these domains are clinical and counseling psychology, which utilizes the knowledge accumulated by the theory-based domains of psychology to enhance individuals' mental health and well-being. Industrial and organizational psychology applies psychological concepts and theories to maximize work effectiveness. Forensic and criminal psychology applies psychological knowledge in the law and legal systems by clarifying perpetrators' mental states as well as their motives and psychological profiles. Lastly, sport psychology applies psychological theories to optimize performance and well-being of athletes.

Regardless of their domains of expertise, psychologists always rely on research evidence in their work. Applied psychologists use research evidence as a key selection criterion when selecting psychological knowledge for subsequent applications. Additionally, these psychologists also contribute to research investigations by identifying gaps or

questions in their work and conducting investigations to answer these questions. Also, these questions may be brought up for further investigation by research psychologists working in the theory-based domains. With these, psychological knowledge becomes expanded and more applicable to various domains of living.

Psychological Applications

The focus of this course will be on how psychology can be applied to enhance the students' daily living, and hence their adjustment. With technological progress, assumptions are sometimes made readily that adjustment will simply follow. In contrast, as suggested in the **paradox of progress**, technological advancement does not promise adjustment, but instead can add complexity and make our living even more challenging.

In the modern world, excessive materialism and technological advancement can weaken social ties. Traditional sources of emotional security (e.g., family, community, and religion) have become weaker. Although technological advancement allows new connections to be made around the world, individuals can be overwhelmed by rapid cultural changes if not properly prepared. Therefore, engaging in mindful use of technology, including social media, has become necessary. Relevant tips in doing so including keeping track of usage time, avoiding comparing yourself with others, and maintaining relationship with significant others.

The applications of psychology to enhance ones' adjustment can be done in various domains. For instance, students will be encouraged to reflect on how psychology can be used to explain some phenomena in their own areas of study, to enhance their work and study motivation, to enrich their social relationships, and to take care of their own physical and psychological health. It is hoped that the applications will help enhance the students' overall adjustment.

Additional Resources

Research

Misconceptions about Psychological Science: A Review

- Explaining the definition, causes, consequences, and methods to reduce misconceptions
- <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.2304/plat.2013.12.1.20>

Does psychology make a significant difference in our lives?

- Explaining how psychology can influence our lives with examples of real-world applications across different contexts (e.g., personal development, parenting, work, human factors, health, and education)
- <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/15511121/>
- <https://citeseerx.ist.psu.edu/viewdoc/download?doi=10.1.1.318.7824&rep=rep1&type=pdf>

Application

Why We Can't Always Trust Common Sense?

- Our common sense/intuitions regarding human behavior are not always accurate. That's why we need psychological science
- <https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/beyond-school-walls/202102/why-we-cant-always-trust-common-sense>

Evidence-Based Living: Bridging the gap between research and real-life

- The applications of research findings to improve people's lives in various topics
- <https://www.psychologytoday.com/intl/blog/evidence-based-living>

Psychology Practices to Lead Yourself Through a Crisis

- Examples of how psychology knowledge can be applied to help one's adjustment during the pandemic
- <https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/self-leadership/202102/9-psychology-practices-lead-yourself-through-crisis>